higher profile. But that perhaps is an overly formal way of approaching what is a complex challenge. Getting a large number of countries with distinctive histories and diverse cultures to collect around a shared ocean space requires both institutional and informal solutions. Building blocks do exist, once we start thinking of them in that manner.

In this uncertain world, if there is a point of agreement, it is that the salience of alliances is decreasing. It is equally apparent that old-fashioned military rivalries are giving way to more subtle competitions for influence. The future is to get nations whose interests are aligned or even overlap to work together. That would mean agendas and conversations with a more open mind. And an appreciation for what each player can bring to the table. This trend is visible already in naval exercises, strategic consultations or infrastructure projects.

Stability and order cannot be built only on the strength of capabilities. It must be tempered by the discipline of law, in this case respect for UNCLOS, which was recognized by IORA as the constitution for the oceans. Recognizing the growing importance of maritime trade in an increasingly globalized world, India supports freedom of navigation and overflight, and unimpeded commerce, based on the principles of international law, as reflected notably in the UNCLOS. India also believes that States should resolve disputes through peaceful means without threat or use of force and exercise self-restraint in the conduct of activities that could complicate or escalate disputes affecting peace and stability. Sea lanes of communication are critical for peace, stability, prosperity and development. As a State Party to the UNCLOS, India has urged all parties to show utmost respect for the convention, which establishes the international legal order of the seas and oceans. It is also our position that the authority of Annex VII Tribunal and its awards is recognized in Part XV of the UNCLOS itself.

If the Indian Ocean is now to occupy a more prominent place in the global political discourse, its best hope is the further development of the IORA. Over two decades, this body has harmonized multiple diversities to create a mixed ethos. It creates common ground for regional economic cooperation and provides opportunities to develop shared interests. It also encourages close interaction of business, academic institutions, scholars and the peoples